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Basics of Technical Communication

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INTRODUCTION

In your academic environment, you encounter various situations involving speech or writing: conversation with your friends, professors, or office staff to achieve various purposes; seminars, group discussions, written tests, and examinations; and laboratory or project report submissions on diverse topics. Likewise, when you take up a profession after completing your studies, you will have to interact with your superiors and subordinates, conversing with them face to face or over the telephone, and read and write e-mails, letters, reports, and proposals.

All these activities have a common denominator—*the sharing of information.* For example, when you request your professor to explain a concept which you could not understand very well in the class, you transmit the information to him that you need some clarification. Now, the professor receives this information, understands it and responds by giving an explanation which clears your doubt. If you are satisfied with this explanation, you thank the professor and the communication comes to an end. If you are still in doubt, you once again request clarification, and the process continues. This process involving the transmission and interchange of ideas, facts, feelings, or courses of action is known as the *process of communication.* You give, get, or share information with others during this process. Whether you communicate orally or in writing, this process essentially remains the same.

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When you become a part of any organization, you need to communicate, and communicate effectively. No organization can survive without communication. All the activities an organization undertakes have communication at their hub. The better your communication skills, the greater are your chances of quick progress. However skilful you may be in other aspects of your work, knowledge, thoughts, and organization, sans communication are of little use. For instance, though you may possess an excellent academic record, you may not emerge victorious in an interview if you are not able to express your ideas clearly to those on the other side of the table. You may have observed that people at the pinnacle of their profession generally have excellent communication skills, one reason for their rapid rise up the ladder of success. So let us find out more about this communication process and what role it plays in an organization.

THE PROCESS OF COMMUNICATION

Communication can be defined as the exchange of information, ideas, and knowledge between sender and receiver through an accepted code of symbols.

The word communication has its root in the Latin word *communicare*, which means *to share*, and this sharing is of information, knowledge, and thoughts. For sharing information, you require two parties, the sender and the receiver, without which communication cannot take place. However, it is not sufficient to have two parties; there should also be cooperation and understanding between them. They should have a mutually accepted code of signals making up a common language. So communication can be defined as the exchange of information, ideas, and knowledge between sender and receiver through an accepted code of symbols. It is termed effective only when the receiver receives the message intended by the sender in the same perspective. Otherwise it is miscommunication.

The Communication Cycle

Consider the communication process as shown in Figure 1.1.

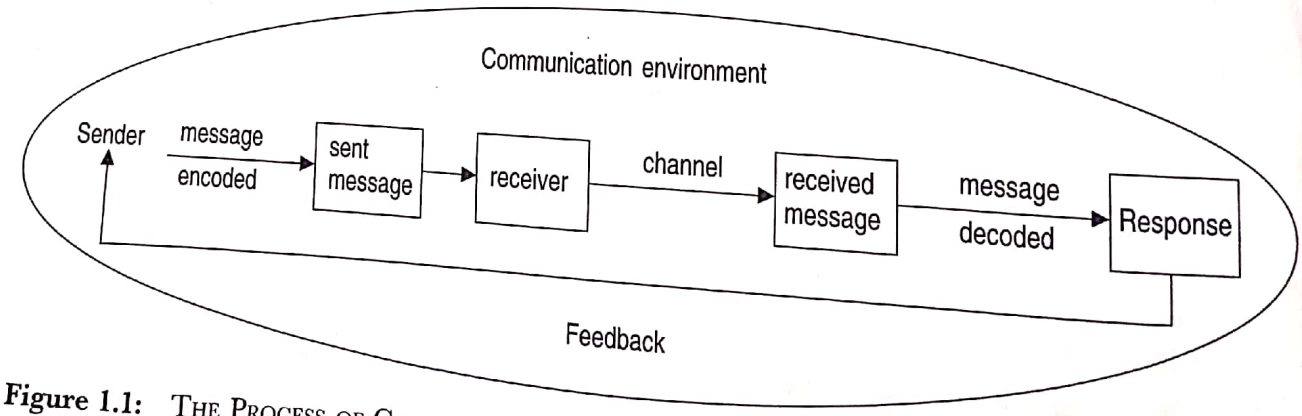


Figure 1.1: THE PROCESS OF COMMUNICATION

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The *sender* encodes the *message* and sends it through a *channel.* *This channel is nothing but the language used*—words, actions, signs, objects, or a combination of these. The *receiver* receives the message, decodes it, and acts on it. If the message received is the same as the message sent, there will be a response; if not, there has been a breakdown of communication. This may happen because of 'noise'. The reasons for noise production have been discussed in detail in the latter part of this section.

The transmission of the receiver's response to the sender is called *feedback.* Feedback is essential as it is a barometer of effective communication. If you are sending a message to somebody, your communication cycle is complete only when you get a response from the recipient of your message. Otherwise, you need to resend the message. Of course, even if you receive a response, it may or may not be the one you had expected. But once you receive some response, you know that you have communicated your message to the other party successfully. For example, you put up a notice asking the members of your student council to attend a meeting on a specified date, at a particular time, at the location mentioned. On the day of the meeting, you find that some of them have come while the others have not turned up. In this case you have obtained both the positive and negative responses to your message. But since you have got some feedback, the communication process is complete. Also, it has been effective, at least from your side. Hence, to understand whether you have communicated successfully or not, you must get feedback which is your observation of the recipient's response. Your communication is fully effective only when you get the desired response from the receiver.

Communication takes place in a well-defined set-up. This is called the *communication environment.* A classroom is the communication environment when a teacher delivers lectures to students. A teacher's cubicle becomes the communication environment when a student privately approaches the teacher.

Messages themselves are transferred through a medium, the *channel.* In oral communication, the air or telephone wires are commonly used channels. Language is the tool we use through these channels to exchange information.

In brief, the *essentials of effective communication* are:

- A common communication environment
- Cooperation between the sender and the receiver
- Selection of an appropriate channel
- Correct encoding and decoding of the message
- Receipt of the desired response and feedback

Noise

When you communicate, you desire that the message received should be the same as the message sent. But you might notice that this is not always the case.

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Noise is defined as any unplanned interference in the communication environment, which causes hindrance in the transmission of the message.

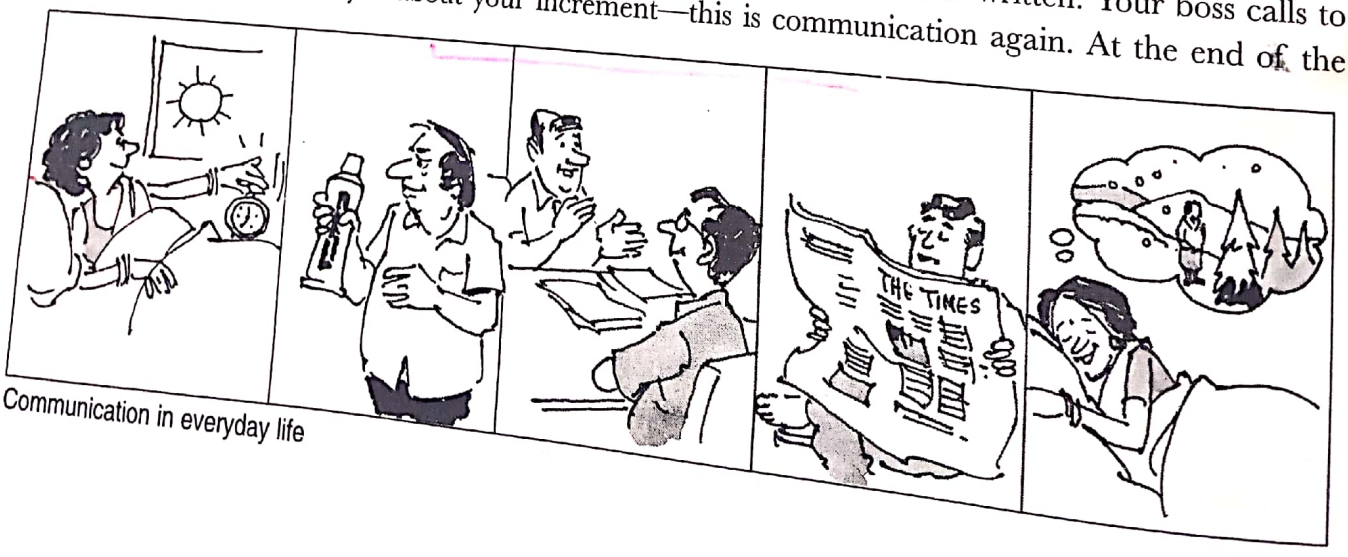
Sometimes, this is due to the presence of *noise*. *Noise is defined as any unplanned interference in the communication environment, which causes hindrance in the transmission of the message.* Noise distorts *interpretation* or the decoding part of the communication process.

Noise can be classified as *channel* and *semantic*. *Channel noise is any interference in the mechanics of the medium used to send a message.* Familiar examples of channel noise are distortion due to faulty background, noise in telephone lines, or too high a volume or pitch from loudspeakers. In written communication, illegible handwriting can be termed as channel noise.

Whereas channel noise develops externally, *semantic noise is generated internally, resulting from errors in the message itself.* It may be because of the connotative meaning of a word allowing the meaning to be interpreted differently by the sender and the receiver. For example, the word 'condescend' may be used in a positive manner, implying *graciousness* or *dignity of manner*, but the receiver might interpret it in a negative manner, related to *a (baseless) assumption of superiority*. Other examples of semantic noise are ambiguous sentence structure, faulty grammar, misspellings, and incorrect punctuation.

General and Technical Communication

Communication is important not only in an organization but also in daily life. In everyday life, you will find that communication occurs everywhere. It is an integral part of daily activity. When your alarm clock goes off, it is communication through sound and urges you get out of bed. When you use a particular brand of toothpaste while brushing your teeth, it is because of the impact of the company's persuasive advertising or its salesman's spiel, both being effective forms of communication. You watch the morning news on TV—communication. You say goodbye to your family as you leave home—this is communication. You call for a cab and tell the driver to head for your office—this is communication. At your work place, all activities revolve around communication, be it oral or written. Your boss calls to tell you about your increment—this is communication again. At the end of the



Communication in everyday life

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day, you return home and read the newspaper—this is communication once more. Finally, you retire to bed and dream—this is also communication, this time with yourself. Messages that are non-technical or informal in nature are categorized as general purpose communication, whereas messages pertaining to technical, industrial, or business matters belong to the category of technical or business communication. Table 1.1 shows the differences between the two categories.

Table 1.1: Characteristics of General and Technical Communication

General communication	Technical communication
• Contains a general message • Informal in style and approach • No set pattern of communication • Mostly oral • Not always for a specific audience • Doesn't involve the use of technical vocabulary or graphics, etc.	• Contains a technical message • Mostly formal • Follows a set pattern • Both oral and written • Always for a specific audience • Frequently involves jargon, graphics, etc.

LANGUAGE AS A TOOL OF COMMUNICATION

Language employs a combination of words to communicate ideas in a meaningful way. By changing the word order in a sentence, you can change its meaning, and even make it meaningless.

It is a well-established fact that effective communication is made possible with the help of language. You do not have to be a linguist in order to acquire good language skills. However, a basic knowledge of the theory of language will certainly help you to understand the intricacies of writing and speaking clearly. So let us look at some of the basic features of language.

When you try to define language, the first thing that comes to mind is *words*. Language employs a combination of words to communicate ideas in a meaningful way. By changing the word order in a sentence, you can change its meaning, and even make it meaningless.

How did words acquire their meanings? What, for example, is the connection between a wooden plank balanced on four legs and the word 'table'? The answer is that there is no obvious correlation between the symbol and its meaning, as language is arbitrary. When language first came into being, a community of people agreed to represent a certain object or idea by a specific sound or symbol. In the very first words, there may have been some correlation between the symbol and the sense—they may have been onomatopoeic. A few such words that still persist in the English language are *buzz, drizzle,* and *murmur.* In fact most words evoke certain meanings because people have agreed that the symbols (words) represent specific meanings. Thus language is directly dependent on people and cannot exist in isolation. It arose out of the human need to communicate. Primitive man communicated only with sign language and cries. Much later, as human beings became more interdependent and complex, language came into being. Of course, though it is accepted that language is universal, it cannot be denied that it is also

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LEVELS OF COMMUNICATION

Human communication takes place at various levels:

- extrapersonal
- intrapersonal
- interpersonal
- organizational
- mass

Extrapersonal Communication



Communication between human beings and non-human entities is extrapersonal. For example, when your pet dog comes to you wagging its tail as soon as you return home from work, it is an example of extrapersonal communication. A parrot responding to your greeting is another example. More than any other form, this form of communication requires perfect coordination and understanding between the sender and the receiver as at least one of them transmits information or responds in sign language only.

Intrapersonal Communication

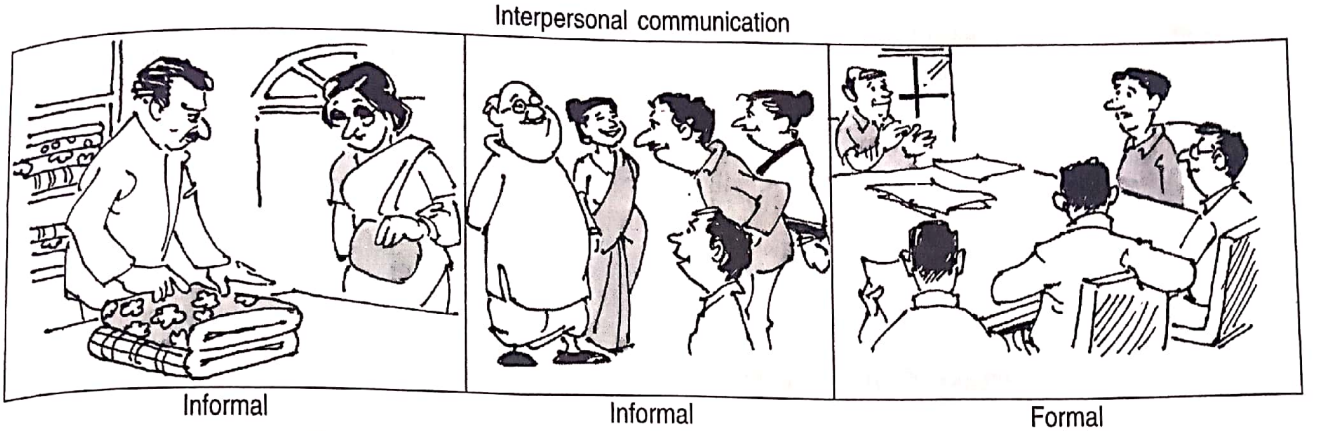
This takes place within the individual. We know that the brain is linked to all the parts of the body by an electrochemical system. For example, when you begin to 'feel hot', the information is sent to the brain and you may decide to 'turn on the cooler', responding to instructions sent from the brain to the hand. In this case, the relevant organ is the sender, the electrochemical impulse is the message, and the brain is the receiver. Next, the brain assumes the role of sender and sends the feedback that you should switch on the cooler. Then the process is complete. This kind of communication pertains to thinking, which is the basis of information processing. Without such internal dialogue, you cannot proceed to the further levels of communication—interpersonal and organizational. In fact, while we are communicating with the other party, internal dialogue with oneself continues concurrently—planning, weighing, considering, and processing information. You might have noticed that at times you motivate yourself or consciously resolve to complete a certain task. Self-motivation, self-determination, and the like take place at the intrapersonal level.

Interpersonal Communication

Communication at this level refers to the sharing of information among people. To compare it with other forms of communication, we need to examine how many people are involved, how close they are to one another physically, how many sensory channels are used, and the feedback provided.

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Interpersonal communication



Informal Informal Formal

Interpersonal communication differs from other forms of communication in that there are few participants involved, the interactants are in close physical proximity to each other, there are many sensory channels used, and feedback is immediate. Also, the roles of sender and receiver keep alternating. This form of communication is advantageous because direct and immediate feedback is possible. If a doubt occurs, it can be instantly clarified. Note that non-verbal communication plays a major role in the interpretation of a message in this form of communication due to the proximity of the people involved.

Interpersonal communication can be *formal* or *informal*. For example, your interaction with a sales clerk in a store is different from that with your friends and family members; the interaction between the panel members and the candidate appearing at an interview is different from the conversation between two candidates waiting outside. Hence, depending upon the formality of the situation, interpersonal communication takes on different styles.

Moreover, most interpersonal communication situations depend on a variety of factors, such as the psychology of the two parties involved, the relationship between them, the situation in which the communication takes place, the surrounding environment, and finally the cultural context.

Organizational Communication

Communication in an organization takes place at different hierarchical levels. It is extremely necessary for the sustenance of any organization. Since a large number of employees are involved in several different activities, the need to communicate becomes greater in an organization. With a proper networking system, communication in an organization is possible even without direct contact between employees. This kind of communication can be further divided into:

- **internal-operational**

  All communication that occurs in conducting work within an organization is classified as internal-operational.

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- **external-operational**
  The work-related communication that an organization does with people outside the organization is called external-operational.
- **personal**
  All communication in an organization that occurs without purpose as far as business is concerned is called personal communication.

You will learn more about communication in organizations in the sections The Flow of Communication and Communication Networks later in this chapter.

Mass Communication

For this kind of communication we require a mediator to transmit information. These are several mass media such as journals, books, television, and newspapers, which mediate such communications. Since the messages are for a large audience that is heterogeneous and anonymous, the approach is impersonal. Press interviews given by the chairman of a large firm, advertisements for a particular product or service, and the like take place through mass media. This type of communication is more persuasive in nature than any other form of communication and requires utmost care on the part of the sender in encoding the message. Oral communication through mass media requires some equipment, such as microphones, amplifiers, etc., and the written form needs print or visual media. The characteristics of this type of communication are:

- **large reach**
  Mass media communications reach audience scattered over a wide geographical area.
- **impersonality**
  This kind of communication is largely impersonal as the participants are unknown to each other.
- **presence of a gatekeeper**
  Mass communication needs additional persons, institutions or organizations to convey the message from sender to receiver. This 'gatekeeper' or mediator could be a person or an organized group of persons active in transferring or sending information from the source to the target audience through a mass medium. For example, in a newspaper the editor makes choices and decides which news makes it to the hands of the reader. The editor is therefore the gatekeeper in the mass communication process.

THE FLOW OF COMMUNICATION

Information flows in an organization both formally and informally. *The term formal communication refers to communication that follows the official hierarchy and is required to do*

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one's job. In other words, it flows through formal channels—the main lines of organizational communication. Internal-operational and external-operational communication can be described as formal. In fact, the bulk of communication that a business needs in order to operate flows through these channels. For example, when a manager instructs a subordinate on some matter or when an employee brings a problem to a supervisor's attention, the act of communication is formal. Similarly, when two employees interact to discuss a customer's order, there is a formal communication. Information of various kinds flowing through formal channels, such as policy or procedural changes, orders, instructions, confidential reports, etc., is classified as formal communication. This type of communication can flow in various directions—downward, upward, lateral, or diagonal—as shown in Figure 1.2.

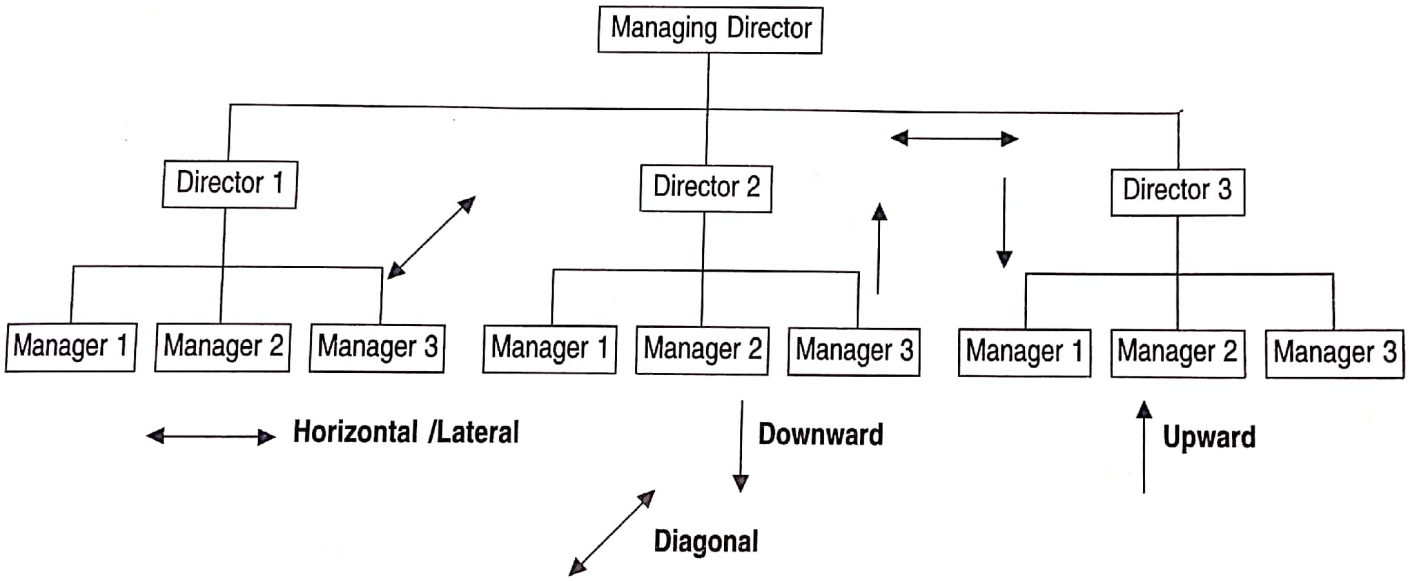


Figure 1.2: FLOW OF COMMUNICATION IN AN ORGANIZATION

Downward Communication

Downward communication flows from a manager, down the chain of command. When managers inform, instruct, advise, or request their subordinates, the communication flows in a downward pattern. This is generally used to convey routine information, new policies or procedures, to seek clarification, to ask for an analysis, etc. Also, superiors send feedback about their subordinates' action through this channel. Such communication increases awareness about the organization among subordinates and employees and enables managers to evaluate the performance of their subordinates. Downward communication can take any form—memos, notices, face to face interactions, or telephone conversations. However, this should be adequately balanced by an upward flow of communication.

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Upward Communication

When subordinates send reports to inform their superiors or to present their findings and recommendations, the communication flows upward. This type of communication keeps managers aware of how employees feel about their jobs, colleagues and the organization in general. Managers also rely on upward communication for making certain decisions or solving some problems which concern the organization.

The extent of upward communication, especially that which is initiated from at the lowest level depends on the organizational culture. In an open culture without too many hierarchical levels, managers are able to create a climate of trust and respect, and implement participative decision-making or empowerment. Here, there will be considerable upward communication. This is mainly because employees provide the input for managerial decisions. In a highly authoritative environment, where downward flow dominates, upward communication still takes place but it is limited to the managerial ranks. Suggestion boxes, employee attitude surveys, grievance procedures, superior-subordinate decisions (decisions taken for the subordinate by his superior), review reports, statistical analyses, etc. provide restricted information to top management.

Lateral or Horizontal Communication

This form of communication takes place among peer groups or hierarchically equivalent employees. Such communication is often necessary to facilitate coordination, save time, and bridge the communication gap among various departments. Occasionally, these lateral relationships are formally sanctioned. But generally, they are informally created to bypass the formal hierarchical channels and expedite action.

From the organization's point of view, lateral communication can be either advantageous or disadvantageous. As compared to vertical (downward or upward) communication, which can at times impede and delay timely and accurate transfer of information, lateral communication can be beneficial. Nevertheless, they can also create conflicts when formal vertical channels are bypassed by employees in order to accomplish their goals, or when superiors find out that they had not been consulted before certain decisions were taken.

Lateral communication enables the sharing of information with a view to apprise the peer group of activities of a department. The Vice President (Marketing) sending some survey results in the form of a memo to the Vice President (Production) for further action is an example of lateral communication. This type of communication is very vital for the growth of an organization as it builds cooperation among the various branches. In such organizations where work is

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decentralized, it plays a greater role because there is a higher probability of communication gaps.

Diagonal or Cross-wise Communication

Diagonal or Cross-wise Communication flows in all directions and cuts across functions and levels in an organization. For example, when a sales manager communicates directly with the Vice President (Production), who is not only in a different division, but also at a higher level in the organization, they are engaged in diagonal communication. Though this form of communication deviates from the normal chain of command, there is no doubt that it is quick and efficient.

In some situations, ignoring vertical and horizontal channels expedites action and prevents other employees from being used merely as conduits between senders and receivers.

The increased use of e-mail also encourages cross-wise communication. Any employee can communicate via e-mail with another employee, regardless of the receiver's function or status. Since there is no specific line of command, diagonal communication is also referred to as cross-wise, radial, or circular communication, depending upon the structure of the organization. For instance, a Managing Director could directly call a supervisor and give instructions.

COMMUNICATION NETWORKS

A variety of patterns emerge when communication combines through vertical and horizontal channels. These patterns are termed as *communication networks*.

Formal Network Models

There are five common communication networks that come into play in formal communication in an organization as discussed below:

i) The *chain network* represents a vertical hierarchy in which communication can flow only upward or downward. We can find this type of network in direct line of authority communications with no deviations.

Formal network models

- chain network
- Y-network
- wheel network
- circle network
- all-channel network

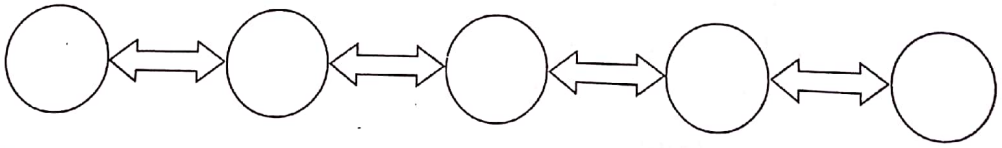


Figure 1.3: CHAIN NETWORK

ii) The *Y-network* is in effect a multi-level hierarchy and a combination of horizontal and vertical flow of communication. If we turn the Y upside down, we see two subordinates reporting to one senior, with two levels of authority above the latter (Figure 1.4).

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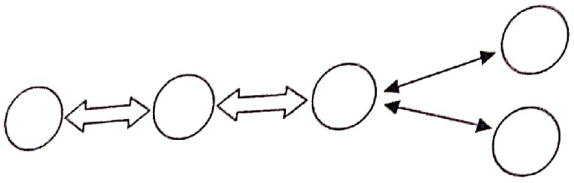


Figure 1.4: Y-NETWORK

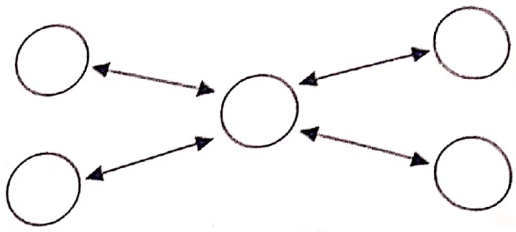


Figure 1.5: WHEEL NETWORK

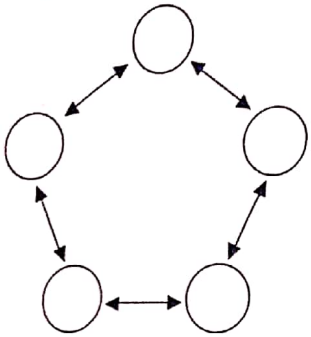


Figure 1.6: CIRCLE NETWORK

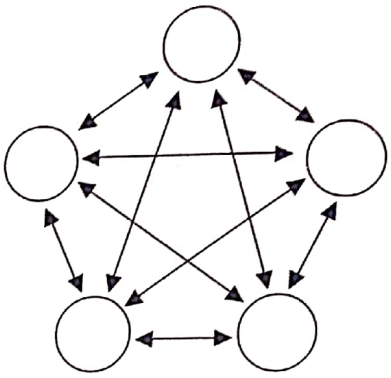


Figure 1.7: ALL-CHANNEL NETWORK

iii) The *wheel network* refers to several subordinates reporting to a superior. This is a combination of horizontal and diagonal flow of communication. But here though the subordinates are of equal rank, all of them report to one superior, and without any interaction between themselves (Figure 1.5).

iv) The *circle network* allows employees to interact with adjacent members but no further. Look, for example, at this three-level hierarchy. There is vertical communication between superiors and subordinates, and horizontal communication only at the lowest level (Figure 1.6).

v) The *all-channel* network, which is least structured, enables each employee to communicate freely with the others. There are no restrictions on who can communicate with whom. All are equal as no one employee formally or informally assumes a leading role. Hence, everybody's views are equally and openly shared (Figure 1.7).

Finally, for effective use of communication networks, we need to remember the following:

- No single network is suitable for all occasions.
- The wheel and all-channel networks are preferred if speed of communication is a priority.
- The chain, Y and wheel networks serve best when accuracy is crucial.

Informal Network Models

Besides flowing through the formal networks, communication in an organization also travels along an informal network—the *grapevine*. This informal network is

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Figure 1.8: SINGLE STRAND

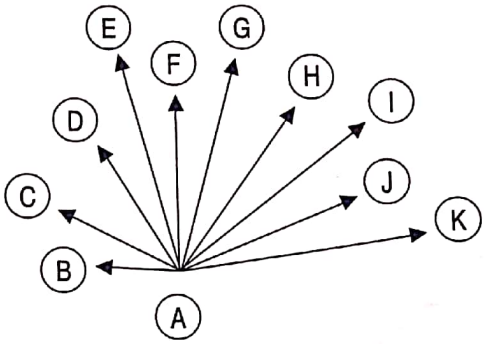


Figure 1.9: GOSSIP

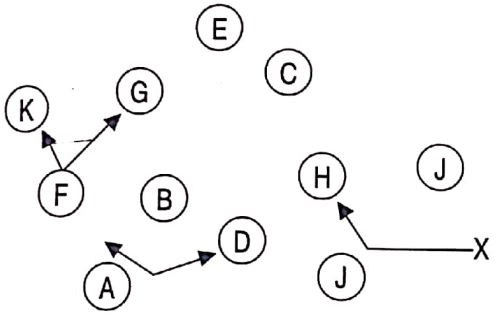


Figure 1.10: PROBABILITY

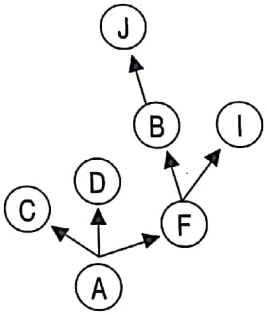


Figure 1.11: CLUSTER

Informal network models

- *Single strand*
- *gossip*
- *probability*
- *cluster*

very active in almost every organization. In fact, some organizations consciously use it to great effects, to develop their human resources, and in turn, their productivity. For example, Michael Eisner, the Chairman of Walt Disney, adopts MBWA or management by walking around. He goes around the company, talks to employees, observes them talking among themselves, and uses this knowledge effectively to adopt or change certain strategies.

There appear to be patterns emerging for this type of informal communication as well (Figures 1.8–1.11).

Among the four patterns shown in the figures, *single strand* is the way in which most people view the grapevine. Here, the message is passed from one person to another along a single strand.

In the *gossip* network one person passes information to all the others. In the *probability* type of network, each person tells others at random. But *cluster*, the most popular pattern of grapevine communication, refers to that flow of information in which some people tell a selected few of the others. Which individuals are active on the grapevine often depends on the message. For example, a message that sparks the interest of an employee may stimulate him or her to tell someone

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Table 1.2: CHARACTERISTICS OF GRAPEVINE

Advantages	Disadvantages
In general, the grapevine is: • not expensive • rapid • multidirectional • if carefully cultivated, is capable of resolving conflicts • a measure of public opinion • serves as an outlet for anxieties, worries, frustration • promotes unity, solidarity • voluntary and unforced	If information from the grapevine is blindly accepted it may: • reveal some degree of error • be harmful in case it is baseless or imaginary • lead to misunderstanding because of incomplete information • not be reliable, as nobody takes the responsibility for it • cause damage to the organization because of its excessive swiftness at times (e.g. a baseless rumour that is not clarified in time will be accepted as truth causing a negative impact)

else, whereas another message that is perceived to be of lesser interest may never be transmitted further.

Since only a small number of employees typically pass on information to more than one other person, managers can analyse grapevine information and predict its flow. Both advantages and disadvantages arise from the grapevine (Table 1.1).

On balance, however, the advantages to an organization of using the grapevine seem to outweigh the drawbacks. To effectively use this channel, organizations

- should not ignore information received through the grapevine;
- should use this channel to supplement the formal channel;
- should identify but not threaten the main sources of information; and
- should try to understand the human relationships involved in grapevine communication.

THE IMPORTANCE OF TECHNICAL COMMUNICATION

Technical communication plays a pivotal role in an organization, whether it is a business enterprise, an industry, or an academic institution. All managerial or administrative activities involve communication, be it planning, organizing, recruiting, coordinating, or decision-making. When you write reports, give instructions, or read brochures and manuals, you are involved in the process of communication. Communication serves as an instrument to measure the success or growth of an organization. For example, papers published by research and development organizations bring to light their progress.

The success of any organization is largely recognized by the quality and quantity of information flowing through its personnel. When the CEO of an organization presents his company's achievements in a meeting, each of the participants comes to know of these milestones. The various types of communication not only help an organization to grow, but also enable the communicators to develop certain attributes.

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Sadly, though most professionals are well aware of the importance of communication, they do not develop their skills to good effect in this sphere of work. The higher your position, greater is your need to communicate. A labourer, for example, may not be as involved in communication as a top-level executive. The more you participate in the communication process, the better you develop your skills in collecting and organizing information, analyzing and evaluating facts, appreciating the difference between facts and inferences, and communicating effectively. If you wish to become an effective communicator, you need to communicate, communicate, and communicate. There is no other way out.

Technical communication in an organization can be divided into two parts: oral and written. Both are equally important, as it cannot be specified which of these is used more in an organization. Some forms of oral and written communication in an organization are summarized in Table 1.2.

It is not necessary that all these forms of communication should exist in an organization. If the organization is very large, for example, a university with various affiliated institutions, or a business enterprise with branches across the nation and abroad, it may have all these forms of communication, whereas a smaller educational institution or business may not have all of them. However, an organization becomes an organized whole because of its communication. It is this communication which enables employees to work together. It is the vehicle through which management performs all its functions. It is impossible for an organization to survive without communication, for all its activities would come to a standstill. Therefore, its importance can never be ignored.

Table 1.3: Forms of Oral and Written Communication

Oral Forms	Written Forms
Face-to-face conversations	Memos
Telephone conversations	Letters
Meetings	E-mails
Seminars	Faxes
Conferences	Notices
Dictation	Circulars
Instructions	Newsletters
Presentations	Reports
Group discussions	Proposals
Interviews (employment, press)	Research papers
Video conferences	Bulletins
Voice conferences	Brochures
	Manuals
	In-house journals

EXERCISES

1. State whether the following statements are true or false. Justify your answer in 100 words each.

(i) Communication in an organization means sharing of thoughts, ideas, feelings, and emotions.

(ii) There is no difference between general-purpose communication and technical communication.

(iii) Your communication will be very effective if you use impressive vocabulary and correct grammar.

(iv) Oral communication is more advantageous than written communication as you can clarify your point after observing the response of the receiver.

(v) Since language is recursive in nature, the user can produce innumerable sentences.

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(vi) Technical knowledge, even without communication skills, can make you a successful manager.

(vii) The message sent is not always the same as the message received.

2. Answer the following questions in about 200 words each.

(i) Define the communication process. Also explain it with the help of schematic representation.

(ii) How is feedback important in communication? Give two examples of delayed feedback.

(iii) Explain the flow of communication. Illustrate it with examples from the existing communication patterns in your college/institute.

(iv) What is grapevine? Is it always harmful? If not, why?

3. Projects

(i) Visit a few organizations (academic institutions/ business enterprise/ industries) in the neighbouring area and find out the communication patterns existing there. Classify them into oral and written categories. Also find out the direction in which these flow. Prepare a two-page report on each of your visits.

(ii) Discuss characteristics of language with your friends and collect more examples to illustrate them.

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2 Barriers to Communication

Definition of Noise
WHAT IS NOISE?
Classification of Barriers
INTRAPERSONAL BARRIERS
- *Wrong Assumptions*
- *Varied Perceptions*
- *Differing Backgrounds*
- *Wrong Inferences*
- *Impervious Categories*
- *Categorical Thinking*

INTERPERSONAL BARRIERS
- *Limited Vocabulary*
- *Incongruity of Verbal and Nonverbal Messages*
- *Emotional Outburst*
- *Communication Selectivity*
- *Cultural Variations*
- *Poor Listening Skills*
- *Noise in the Channel*

ORGANIZATIONAL BARRIERS
- *Too Many Transfer Stations*
- *Fear of Superiors*
- *Negative Tendencies*
- *Use of Inappropriate Media*
- *Information Overload*

DEFINITION OF NOISE

Imagine you are a junior executive who has just joined as a trainee in an automobile company. You go to meet your boss, to seek permission for visiting the automobile exhibition being held in Delhi. While you are talking, two of your colleagues also arrive to get your boss's signature on some bills. You fall silent while he signs the bills. After they leave, you resume talking but you find that your boss has not really grasped what you have said earlier. You later analyse this situation, and realise that your colleagues' intervention led to your boss's lack of concentration. As the sender, you had patiently tried to express your wish. But because of 'the noise' or interruption by your colleagues, the receiver, your boss, could not decode your message fully. Hence the communication process failed.

All of us have come across such situations while communicating with parents, friends, or colleagues. Just as we realise the importance of certain resources only when there is a shortage, we become aware of the importance of effective communication only when there is a breakdown in the process. But with conscientious efforts, we can avoid such failures in our communication and make it more effective. The discussion in this chapter on various types of communication barriers will enable you to identify and understand them. This will enable you to overcome such barriers and become a better communicator.

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Communication is effective only if it creates the desired impact on the receiver.

We all know that effective communication is the omphalos of all the business activities of the organization. Even a slight break in communication flow can lead to misunderstanding of the message. Communication is effective only if it creates the desired impact on the receiver. *It has been found that technical communication is as difficult, if not more, as general-purpose communication.* Often, managers get frustrated in their efforts, and end up saying that nobody in the organization understands them. Many employees fail to listen attentively during meetings, or send incomprehensible business letters. Such situations arise due to inadequate communication skills.

There are numerous such problems associated with communication. These need to be addressed in order to ensure that no hiatus occurs in the communication cycle. Problems usually arise because wrong assumptions are made about the person to whom the message is being sent and *sometimes about the message itself.* For example, if the sender of the message is talking about a technical proposal he would be wrong if he makes assumptions about the level of technical knowledge of the receiver. The problem can be resolved to a great extent if the sender of the message analyses his message thoroughly and anticipates the likely response before sending it. This will considerably reduce the chances of communication failure.

If you find a communication error in your message, how should you rectify it? Try to solve the problem immediately in an appropriate manner. You could also think about how such errors could be avoided in future.

If your communication fails to evoke the desired response, following these five steps will set you back on the right path:

- Identify the problem
- Find the cause
- Work on alternative solutions
- Opt for the best solution
- Follow up rigorously

The first step is the most difficult—identifying the problem. You first realise there is a problem when you do not receive the desired feedback. Next, in order to identify and analyse the problem, it is mandatory that you carefully analyse the feedback. For example, your boss has asked you to write a bimonthly report and until the next month you have not produced one. The boss reprimands you for the delay. You reply that you were asked to produce the report bimonthly. The problem here is, to you the term *bimonthly* meant *once in two months*, whereas to your boss it meant *twice in a month*. Later, you look up the dictionary and find that *bimonthly* means *once in two months* as well as *twice a month*!

Having identified the problem, you come to the next step of finding out what caused it. In this situation, we could say it was the choice of words. The third step is to explore possible solutions. In this case, a way out would be to choose the

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words which are more specific in their meaning. Be aware of the subtleties of the language. After thinking through the alternatives, apply the best solution that not only solves the problem, but also does not create any new difficulties. Hence, instead of using the troublesome term *bimonthly*, you can use either *twice in a month* or *once in a fortnight*. After successfully completing all the four steps, you come to the last step, namely *following rigorously*. This means that you must implement the best solution relentlessly. Having once come across a particular communication barrier, you should make a conscious effort to never let it crop up again.

Let us now look in detail at the term *noise* before going on to consider the different barriers to communication.

What is noise?

Noise here does not mean cacophony, but a break in the communication process.

Any interference in the message sent and message received leads to the production of 'noise'. The term communication barrier, or that which inhibits or distorts the message, is an expansion of the concept of noise. Noise here does not mean cacophony, but a break in the communication process. If noise occurs because of technological factors, it is a smaller problem as it can be removed by correcting the technological faults. However, if the noise is due to human error, the parties involved in the communication process need to take corrective measures.

A barrier acts like a sieve, allowing only a part of the message to filter through; as a result, the desired response is not achieved. To communicate smoothly and effectively in an organization, irrespective of your position, you need to know how the barriers operate, why they cause misunderstandings and how to mitigate their negative impact.

CLASSIFICATION OF BARRIERS

How often have you said, 'I meant to say this and not that'? Even with the best intentions, communication barriers crop up and our written and spoken messages are misunderstood. If we classify these barriers according to the processes of message formation and delivery, we get them at three levels:

- Intrapersonal
- Interpersonal
- Organizational

Intrapersonal Barriers

Individuals are unique because of their idiosyncracies. This is mainly because of differences in experience, education, value, and personality. Each of us interpret the same information in different ways as our thinking varies. Certain common

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causes are responsible for the an individual's inbuilt barriers. Let us explore all the causes listed below that lead to these intrapersonal barriers:

- Wrong assumptions
- Varied perceptions
- Differing background
- Wrong inferences
- Impervious categories
- Categorical thinking

Wrong Assumptions

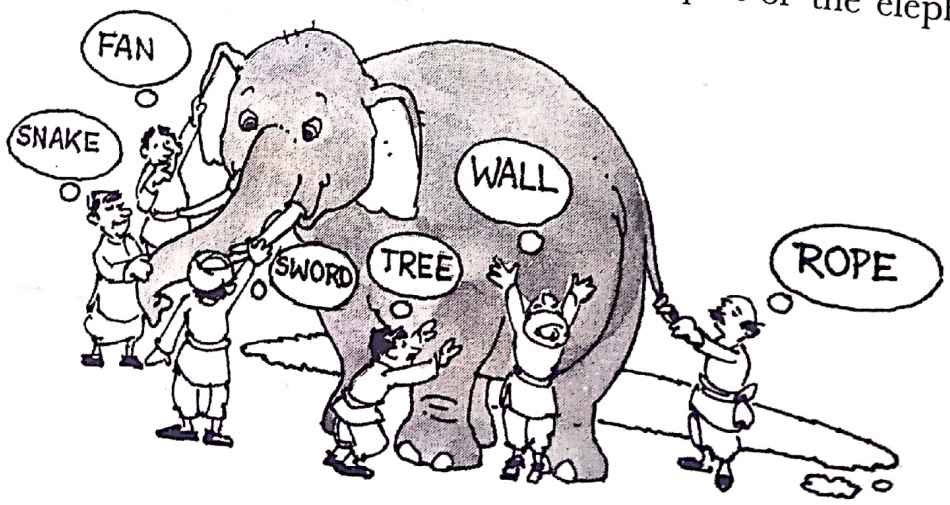


'Take the medicine only SOS.'

Many barriers stem from wrong assumptions. For example, when a doctor tells his patient that he has to take some medicine only 'SOS', without knowing whether the patient understands the term 'SOS', he is creating a barrier in their communication. Here the doctor has made a wrong assumption about his patient's level of knowledge. Wrong assumptions are generally made because the sender or the receiver does not have adequate knowledge about each other's background or entertains certain false notions, which are fixed in their mind. Sometimes the speaker does not realize that backgrounds, education, and experiences of different people can be different. A skilled communicator keeps these issues in mind to prevent them from becoming barriers. To strengthen your skills as a communicator try to put yourself in the shoes of the listener. This exercise will prevent making wrong assumptions about the receiver.

Varied Perceptions

We all know the story of the six blind men and their description of an elephant. The elephant is perceived by each man as a fan, a rope, a wall, a sword, a snake, and a tree. None of the blind men is wrong, as the part of the elephant body



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touched by each man was compared with various objects. This is how an individual perceives reality.

Similarly, individuals in an organization also perceive situations in different ways. Let us take the case of an altercation between two individuals. If you are close to one of them, you are likely to be biased. You may perceive your friend's arguments as correct, and hence, may not be able to appreciate his opponent's point of view. It is all a matter of perception. The best way to overcome this barrier is to step back and take a wider perspective of the issue.

Differing Backgrounds

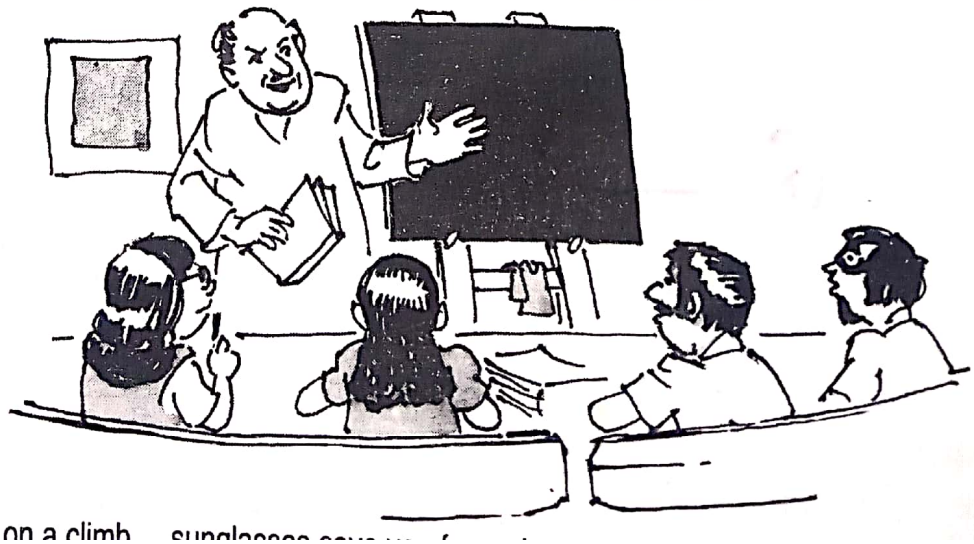
To enhance your communication skills, it is necessary to know the background of your audience. You can accordingly use that information to construct your message.

No two persons have a similar background. Even siblings differ in their genetic inheritance. People vary in terms of their education, culture, language, environment, age, sex, financial status, etc. Our background plays a significant role in how we interpret the message. At times, something not experienced by you earlier will be difficult to interpret or appreciate. Think of a class where the professor talks about his rock climbing adventure. Those students who have had the experience of trekking may be able to appreciate the professor's talk, while others who have never been trekking may not find it interesting at all.

A computer company representative would not make much sense to a group of doctors if in his presentation he goes into details about the hardware aspects of the computer that he has plans to install.

To enhance your communication skills, it is necessary to know the background of your audience. You can accordingly use that information to construct your message.

Empathy or identification with another person is the solution to this barrier. *Make an effort to understand where the listener can find it difficult to comprehend the message because of the difference between your background and that of the listener.* Use language understood by the receiver to avoid ambiguity and reduce multiple meanings in your communication. The meaning of the word resides in the mind of speaker; therefore, one ought to be cautious while using words.



'While on a climb ... sunglasses save ...

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Confusables

Common groups of words are sometimes confused or ignored by users.

Ability is a skill that you have mastered through study or practice. *Capacity* refers to innate talent.

If something *affects* you, it has an effect on you. To *effect* something however means to make something happen: 'The new Management wanted to *effect* drastic changes, but the unions felt these would adversely *affect* workers.'

The multiple meanings of a word increases astronomically the problem of communication barriers. A word can have several connotations and definitions. The more a word is prone to multiple meanings, the greater are the chances of its being misunderstood. A conscientious speaker is careful to explain his message in context by rephrasing and repeating words that can be confusing.

When writing or speaking:

1. Think of your audience. How well do they understand the language? How much do they know about your logic?
2. Select your words with care, especially technical terms. Words must be suited to your audience's language skills.
3. If you *have* to use slightly difficult or unfamiliar words, try to explain these as part of your communication.
4. Don't fall into the trap, however, of oversimplifying your language; your audience could get put off if you use words that sound babyish.

Feedback serves as an effective barometer to find out if the intended message has been put across. Ask the receiver to paraphrase the message and also ask questions on what was said. Even if you have an extensive vocabulary, never use words merely to impress. Rather use them to express your ideas as simply and clearly as possible.

Wrong Inferences

You have returned from a business trip and you find that two of your colleagues are absent. They do not turn up for several days. Since there is a recession on, you draw an inference that they have been laid off. The fact is that they have been promoted and sent to another department. This is an example of *fact-inference confusion*. It has happened because you failed to distinguish between what actually exists and what you had assumed to exist.

Inferences are more dramatic than facts, and for this reason they give more scope for gossip and rumour to burgeon. Inferences supported by facts are essential for professionals when they analyse material, solve problems and plan procedures. Systems analysts, marketing specialists, advertisers, architects, engineers, designers, and others must work on various premises and draw inferences after collecting factual data. When presenting any inference in the course of your work, you

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could use qualifiers such as 'evidence suggest', or 'in my opinion' to remind yourself and the receiver that this is not yet established as fact.

Impervious Categories

In general, we react positively to information only if it is in consonance with our own views and attitudes. Conversely, when we receive information that does not conform to our personal views, habits and attitudes, or appears unfavourable to us, we tend to react negatively or even disbelieve. Rejection, distortion, and avoidance are three common, undesirable, and negative reactions to unfavourable information.

Advances in communication and technologies are so rapid today that many people have difficulty in quickly adapting themselves to these developments. Instead of taking advantage of these developments that expedite the communication process, they tend to resist and criticize them. This is a result of having a closed mind. Such people are called misoneists. They tend to ignore variations and differences, which lead to unreliable conclusions. In some people, certain prejudices are so deeply embedded in the psyche that these cannot be challenged.

Similarly, people who are very rigid in their opinions may face problems in communicating effectively. For example, one of your fellow students may think that only students of science are good in reasoning; another might be of the opinion that young executives are more efficient than older ones. Such people fall into impervious categories, because they may not be able to accept any deviation from their points of view.

Categorical Thinking

People who feel that they 'know it all' are called *pansophists*. This type of thinking exists in people who feel that they know everything about a particular subject, and therefore refuse to accept any further information on that topic. For example, in a General Body meeting of your organization, you are to be briefed about the annual budget. However, you do not pay attention because you feel you have already been briefed about it by your secretary the previous day. Later you propose that new vehicles have to be bought. Imagine your embarrassment when you realize that the topic was discussed and a decision had already been taken in the General Body meeting. This type of thinking can pose a major barrier, leading to a failure in communication. In such instances, the receivers refuse information because of their 'know-it-all' attitude.

The clue to detecting this barrier in others and ourselves is the use of words like *all, always, everybody, everything, every time* and their opposites like *none, never, nobody,* and *nothing*. If a message contains too many of these words, then there is a fair chance of the communication getting distorted. To avoid this barrier, substitute

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these words with phrases like 'in most situations' or 'likely'. Label your opinions with phrases like, 'it appears to me' or 'the evidence indicates'. If your data is insufficient, it is better to admit that you are unaware of the rest of the information rather than stonewalling.

To sum up, good communicators should:

- Be non-judgemental
- Be empathetic
- Not assume anything
- Stick to the subject
- Listen and above all paraphrase

However, you must remember that the generalization does not always hold good in all situations.

Interpersonal Barriers

Intrapersonal barriers stem from an individual's attitudes or habits, whereas interpersonal barriers occur due to the inappropriate transaction of words between two or more people. The two broad categories into which this barrier can be classified are:

- Inefficiency in communication skills
- Negative aspect nurturing in the climate

Interpersonal barriers creep in as a result of the limitations in the communication skills of encoder or decoder, or both. In addition, they may also occur because of some disturbance in the channel. If there are two people involved in communication, the traits that distinguish them as individuals can be the root cause of a communication problem.

In a business environment, we neither attempt to change these traits, nor can we do it; however, we can understand the role of differences among individuals that lead to communication breakdowns. The most common reasons for interpersonal barriers are:

- Limited vocabulary
- Incongruity of verbal and nonverbal messages
- Emotional outbursts
- Communication selectivity
- Cultural variations
- Poor listening skills
- Noise in the channel

Limited Vocabulary

An inadequate vocabulary can be a major hindrance in communication. At times, your pen falters, or your tongue fumbles as you search for the exact word or phrase. In your communication, the connotative and denotative meanings of your

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Some pointers to good word usage:

1. **Be positive** We all have a 'passive vocabulary'—words we know but never use. There are also words we have read or have a vague idea about. Try shifting these words into the vocabulary that you are familiar with and use.
2. **Dictionary and Thesaurus** These are invaluable tools. Use a dictionary to check the meanings of words. Make sure you can use it easily and confidently. A thesaurus will give you all the options to a word, so that you can choose the best one for the occasion.
3. **A wide choice** Remember, English gives you several choices of words for a single meaning. When you write, don't opt for the first word that comes to mind. Make an effort to think of other words. Use a thesaurus to help you in your work.
4. **Who is your audience?** When speaking or writing, always keep your audience in mind. Communication is a two-way street. Use words that are in keeping with your audience's level of language skills and their knowledge of the subject.
5. **Social setting** Do you have an informal or formal relationship with your audience? Words that suit one social setting could be disastrous in another and ruin your communication, however accurate your language may be. Choose your style of speaking or writing according to the occasion.
6. **Jargon** Unless your target audience is in the know, jargon tends to put off people. Avoid it!
7. **New words** Just as words fall into disuse and vanish from the language, new words are constantly being added. Some words will last and become widely used; others will fade away. While it is interesting to try out new words, be wary of trying to sound 'fashionable' all the time, or you will end up looking ridiculous.
8. **Sentence construction** Learn how words work in sentences before you can start developing your vocabulary. This will greatly benefit you, especially in writing.
9. **Understand word structure** Many words have common 'building blocks'—try to figure out how these work. Also try to understand how common prefixes and suffixes are used in constructing new words.
10. **Enjoy the language!** English is an amazingly creative, flexible language, capable of assimilating various influences and expressing subtleties of thought. As Thomas Carlyle said, 'Be not the slave of words'. Don't let words scare you—rather, get a hold on them and enjoy using them in your speaking and writing.

words should be absolutely clear to the receiver. During your speech, if you are at a loss for words, your communication will be very ineffective, and you will leave a poor impression on the audience. On the other hand, if you have a varied and substantial vocabulary, you can create an indelible impression on your listeners.

Do remember also that merely having a good vocabulary is of no use unless the communicator knows how to use it. Therefore, one should make constant efforts to increase one's vocabulary by regularly reading a variety of books and listening to native speakers of the language.

Incongruity of Verbal and Non-verbal Messages

Imagine a situation where your CEO introduces the newly recruited middle level manager to the other employees. In a small speech, he conveys the message that he is very delighted to have the new manager appointed in his office. However,

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'Did whatever I said in the last half hour make any sense to you?'

the expression on his face shows just the opposite of what he is saying. The stark difference between the verbal and non-verbal aspects of his communication leaves his listeners feeling confused and puzzled. A communicator should acclimatize himself to communication environment, think from the angle of the listener, and then communicate.

Misinterpreted non-verbal communication acts as another barrier to effective information gathering. Non-verbal communication usually enhances and enlivens verbal communication. Actions speak louder than words, and thus, non-verbal cues provide a deeper insight into the sender's message. Ignoring non-verbal cues or misinterpreting them can result in the message being completely misunderstood. Thus, one should not only try to accurately gauge others' non-verbal cues but also be aware of one's own body language.

Generalizations, based on assumptions about physical appearance or dress, can also lead to severe communication barriers. *Physical appearance often serves as one of the most important non-verbal cues. First impressions regarding people are made on the basis of physical appearance.* For instance, people initially formed negative impressions of Einstein because of his haggard appearance. It is important to remember that physical appearance can have a great impact on any kind of conversation.

Guidelines to improve your appearance:

- Dress according to the occasion
- Wear neat and clean clothes
- Choose an appropriate hairstyle
- Wear clean and polished shoes

While interpretation of non-verbal cues requires keen observation, there are also pitfalls to guard against. For instance, there is great disparity in the use and interpretation of non-verbal messages across countries and cultures. For example, in Kenya, a mother-in-law and a son-in-law avoid eye contact. In fact they turn their backs to each other. In America, this would be a sign of disrespect.

In brief, your non-verbal cues should consistently match your verbal messages, adding to their effectiveness and enhancing your image as a competent and interesting communicator.

Emotional Outburst

Imagine that you are the President of a well-established company. There are rumours floating amongst your employees that you have indulged in fraudulent activities. You are fully aware that these rumours are baseless. However, when

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you are asked to address the same employees, you are unable to put your point across, as you are flushed with anger. Despite the fact that you are a confident public speaker, your communication failed as you were overwhelmed by your emotions.

In most cases, a moderate level of emotional involvement intensifies communication, making it more personal. However, excessive emotional involvement can be an obstacle in communication. For example, extreme anger can create such an emotionally charged environment that rational discussion is just not possible. Likewise, prejudice, stereotyping, and boredom all hinder effective communication. Positive emotions like happiness and excitement also interfere in communication, but to a lesser extent than negative feelings.

Emotions are an integral part of our being, whether in business or personal encounters. By sharpening self-awareness, intuition, and empathy, emotions can help in developing an environment highly conducive to good communication.



Yet, situations often arise where people react negatively. Depending on their nature and the situation, this negative reaction may either be classified as hostile or defensive. Hostility can be considered as a move to counter-attack the threat, whereas defensiveness is resistance to it. Both occur in situations where the receiver of the message perceives some kind of threat. Both these responses have an extremely negative impact on the communication. Messages are either misinterpreted, ignored, or overreacted to by people displaying such behaviour. Those who witness such behaviour are most likely to lower their opinion about the sender of such messages.

It is important to maintain one's composure in all kinds of communications. Viewing issues from different perspectives helps develop objectivity and rational thinking, which in turn can eliminate many of the causes of hostility or defensiveness.

If you are confronted with such negative behaviour, it is essential that you do not retaliate. The person displaying these emotions should be calmed down. He should preferably be taken to a quiet place to try and sort out the problem that caused his emotions to spin out of control.

Usually, in such exchanges, the volume of both the sender and receiver increases, with stress more on the volume than on the message. Therefore, it is important that the situation be checked at the outset, when the volume increases.

Communication Selectivity

If you are the receiver in a communication process, and you pay attention only to a part of the message, you are imposing a barrier known as *communication selectivity*. You do this because you are interested only in that part of the message which may be of use to you. In such a situation, the sender is not at fault. It is the receiver who breaks the flow of communication.

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Take for example, a meeting held by the chairman of a company. He has called all his senior executives from various divisions—production, marketing, finance, personnel, etc. During the meeting he discusses diverse topics. But, he may not be able to get across the entire message to each one of the participants, unless he gets their undivided attention. If the production manager and the marketing manager pay attention only to matters related to their respective areas, they may not be able to get the total perspective of what the chairman is conveying. Communication selectivity may act as a barrier in written forms of communication as well. *When you read a story, if you read only certain parts and omit others, you are posing this barrier.*

Cultural Variations

This is one of the predominant factors in communication failure. As businesses are increasing across national boundaries to compete on a global scale, the outlook of global and domestic work force has changed drastically. European, Asian and American firms have expanded their businesses worldwide to create international ties through partnership, collaborations, and affiliations. The management and employees of such companies need to closely observe the laws, customs, and business practices of their host countries, while dealing with their multinational workforce. To compete successfully in today's globalized business environment, we must overcome the communication inadequacy arising from different languages and cultures.

This holds good in the area of education as well. You will prove to be a successful communicator abroad, during the course of your higher studies, if you take pains to understand the culture of the educational campus in which you would be studying. Your success, whether as a student or as a professional, lies in knowing the business practices, social customs, and etiquette of a particular country.

Poor Listening Skills

A common obstacle to communication is poor listening habits. We should remember that listening and hearing are not the same. Hearing is a passive exercise while listening requires careful attention and accurate decoding of the signals received from the speaker. Misunderstanding and conflicts can be mitigated if people listen to the message with attention. The various distractions that hinder listening can be emotional disturbances, indifference, aggressiveness, and wandering attention.

Sometimes, an individual is so engrossed in his own thoughts and worries that he is unable to concentrate on listening. If a superior goes on shifting the papers on his desk while listening to his subordinate, without making eye contact with the latter, he pays divided attention to the speaker's message. This divided attention adversely affects the superior–subordinate relationship, [illegible] communication.

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'The sales are low! We need to strategize. Call for a brainstorming session in Goa.'

Thus, business executives should be not only good speakers but also better listeners. This can be done by paying proper attention to the speaker through nonverbal responses, and asking questions at the appropriate moment. Do not jump to conclusions hastily, but maintain your composure and allow the speaker to finish before interpreting his message.

Noise in the Channel

Noise interferes greatly in the transmission of signals. Noise is any unwanted signal which acts as a hindrance in the flow of communication. It is not necessarily limited to cacophony, but can also occur in visual, audio-visual, written, physical, or psychological forms. All these forms of noise communicate extraneous matter which may allay the receiver's interest in the message, even irritate him.

Technical or physical noise refers to the din of machines, the blare of music from a stereo system, or other such sounds which make the task of the listener difficult. Human noise can be experienced when, for instance, employees gather for a meeting and a member arrives late distracting everybody's attention. Disturbances in telephone lines, poorly designed acoustics of a room, dim typescripts, and illegible writing are some more examples of technical noise.

Organizational Barriers

In organizations with many levels of communication, messages have a greater chance of being distorted. This occurs due to poor listening, lack of concentration or a person's tendency to leave out part of the message.

Communication barriers are not only limited to an individual or two people but exist in entire organizations. Every organization, irrespective of its size, has its own communication techniques, and each nurtures its own communication climate.

In large organizations where the flow of information is downward, feedback is not guaranteed. Organizations with a flat structure usually tend to have an intricately knit communication network. *Irrespective of size, all organizations have communication* policies which describe the protocol to be followed. It is the structure and complexity of this protocol that usually causes communication barriers.

We have already discussed in detail the formal and informal (grapevine) methods of communication existing in organizations. Most large companies are realizing

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that a rigid, hierarchical structure usually restricts the flow of communication. This is because there are numerous *transfer points,* for communication to flow in these hierarchical systems, and each of these points has the potential to distort, delay, or lose the message. To obviate this, there should be direct contact between sender and receiver with minimum transfer stations. If the message is presented orally, this further reduces the dependence on transfer stations.

The main organizational barriers are enumerated below.

Too Many Transfer Stations

The more links there are in a communication chain, the greater are the chances of communication that will occur. Imagine for instance, that your professor asks you to convey a message to *X*. You, because of some inconvenience or sheer laziness, ask your friend *Y* to do this job. Now, there are four people involved in this communication channel. Let us see how the message gets distorted as a result of the increased number of transfer stations:

Professor: *X* was supposed to meet me today regarding the submission of an assignment on Magnetic Theory. But I want *X* to meet me on Friday, as I am going out of station tomorrow.

You (to your friend)**:** Ask *X* to meet the professor tomorrow, regarding the assignment, as the professor is going out of station today.

Your friend *Y* (to *X*)**:** *X*, you have to meet the professor today as he will not be available tomorrow.

After going through this example, you will be able to appreciate how messages get distorted in huge organizations, with several layers of communication channels. The message gets distorted at each level not only because of poor listening or lack of concentration, but also because of several other reasons. Some employees may filter out a part of the message which they consider unimportant. Whatever the reasons for filtering or distorting the message, having too many transfer stations is always a deterrent to effective communication and should be avoided. Transfer stations do serve a purpose, but having too many of them is counter productive.

Fear of Superiors

In rigidly structured organizations, fear or awe of the superiors prevents subordinates from speaking frankly. An employee may not be pleased with the way his boss works but is unable to put his point across because of losing his boss's goodwill. As a supervisor, it is essential to create an environment which enables people to speak freely. An open environment is conducive to increasing the confidence and goodwill of a communicator. To avoid speaking directly to their boss, some employees may either shun all communication with their superiors. At

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the other extreme, they may present all the information that they have. This is because they feel that they shall be viewed in an unfavourable light by leaving out some vital information. In written communication, this results in bulky reports, where essential information is clubbed with unimportant details. Such unfocussed messages result in a lot of wasted time. Such practices need to be eliminated by superiors to ensure that communication flows effectively in their organizations. Moreover, by encouraging active participation from their subordinates, senior officers pave the way for more ideas, resources or solutions to come forth from their subordinates.

Negative Tendencies

Many organizations create work groups. While some groups are formed according to the demands of the task, such as accomplishing a particular project, many other small groups are also formed for recreational, social, or community purposes. These groups may be formal or informal, and generally consist of people who share similar values, attitudes, opinions, beliefs, and behaviours. Nevertheless, on some occasions, it is possible to have a communication barrier due to confliction of ideas between members and non-members of a group.

Student members of the sports club of an educational institution may be annoyed with non-members who oppose the club's demand for allocating more funds to purchase sports equipment. This type of opposition gives rise to insider/outsider relationships, which in turn pave the way for negative tendencies in the organization. Once these negative tendencies develop, they create noise in interpersonal communication. However, good managers can take advantage of these situations by considering these groups, not as troubleshooters, but regarding them as reinforcers of the organization's objectives and values. Experienced administrators can even make these groups organize orientation sessions for new recruits, thereby projecting the corporate image.

Use of Inappropriate Media

Some of the common media used in organizations are *graphs* and *charts, telephones, facsimile machines, boards, e-mail, telephones, films* and *slides, computer presentations, teleconferencing,* and *video conferencing*. While choosing the medium you should therefore keep in mind the advantages, disadvantages and potential barriers to communication.

Before sending a message, you should consider the following factors while choosing the medium:

- time
- cost
- type of message
- intended audience

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The telephone, for instance, would not be an ideal medium for conveying confidential information. Such messages are best conveyed in person or, if the receiver is located in another office, by speed post.

Typed letters, which provide permanence, are preferable for information which requires to be stored for future reference.

Usually, a mix of media is best for effective communication. For example, a telephone call to book an order, followed by a confirmatory letter ensures that there is no possible misunderstanding of the message.

Information Overload

One of the major problems faced by organizations today is the availability of huge amounts of data which the receiver is unable to handle effectively. This is known as *information overload.*

The usual results of information overload are fatigue, disinterest, and boredom. Under these circumstances, further communication is simply not possible.

Very often, vital, relevant information gets mixed up with too many irrelevant details, and therefore goes ignored by the receiver. Thus, the *quality* of the information is much more important than the *quantity.*



To reduce information overload in an organization, screening of information is mandatory. Messages should be directed only to those people who are likely to benefit from the information. Major points should be highlighted, leaving out all irrelevant details. This kind of screening will be appreciated by all and can reduce the problem of information overload to a great extent.

We have observed that communication falls into two categories: either it is successful or it is not successful. Bearing in mind the possibilities and reasons for communication failure, you can take preemptive measures to avoid these barriers.

Tips for effective communication: Constant practice and rigorous implementation of these ideas will help you become an excellent communicator.

- Create an open communication environment.
- Always keep the receiver in mind.
- Avoid having too many transfer stations.
- Do not communicate when you are emotionally disturbed.
- Be aware of diversity in culture, language, etc.
- Use appropriate non-verbal cues.
- Select the most suitable medium.
- Analyse the feedback.

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EXERCISES

1. Identify the communication barrier that describes each of the following situations:

(i) 'Every time I have a meeting with Mr Gupta, I end up disagreeing with him about a particular issue'.

(ii) Manager: 'Reeta, where is the report that I asked you to submit on the financial matters of the company?'
Employee: ' I don't remember your asking me to submit a report'.

(iii) Teacher: 'Students, why haven't you submitted the report within the fortnight?'
Students: 'But you asked us to submit it bimonthly!'

(iv) 'This room is horrible to work in. I am able to hear everyone around, and there is no scope for privacy'.

(v) 'It is quite tedious to manually work on the students' records, but I fear using the computer as it might corrupt all our data'.

2. Explain the following terms with reference to communication barriers and give two examples for each term.

(i) Semantic gap
(ii) Negative attitude
(iii) Absence of common frame of reference
(iv) Information overload
(v) 'Know it all'.

3. You have been assigned to host a group of American university students who are visiting your institute for the next two weeks. What can you tell them that will help them fit into the culture on your campus? Make a list of the important behavioural rules they should understand, to communicate effectively with students on your campus. Also point out some problems that might occur if the American students disregard these rules.

4. Identify the barriers that lead to miscommunicatio in the scene described below. How can the manage overcome this barrier?

'I called for a meeting with the supervisors. B none turned up . . . nobody pays attention to me this place . . . it'd be better to quit'.

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